

NOMAD — Reader's Report

CONCEPT: In a near future where synthetic video is indistinguishable from real footage except for a sub-second latency the eye learns to feel, a burnt-out identity-verification worker follows his best friend into a paradise abroad — and finds the paradise is a render, the friend is a machine, and the operation harvesting them both is an arbitrage: northern likenesses kept working in dollars, their originals warehoused where the housing is priced in pesos.

SYNOPSIS: A dead sales department, late. In the lit half of the floor, a nine-hole golf course that used to be a department — a ramp of binders, a mop-bucket water hazard, and the old CEO's office door for hole 7. WILL, CAIRNS and JOHN (late 20s), three men who should have gone home four hours ago, are playing it like it matters. Somewhere in the dark a phone is propped against a stapler, filming; half of what it sees is carpet. On the carpet afterwards they count their years on the floor, and Cairns says the only thing he's got out of nine of them is a chair that leans back really far. It's a joke and it isn't one; he looks to Will for backup and Will studies the ceiling. They drift to the one monitor still glowing — TED'S desk, Ted not seen since March, his cardigan on the chair, his face attending a standup on screen. HR renewed his parking pass. Then Cairns teaches them a handshake — fist, fist, roll, and a dumb open-handed beat on the end — which they get wrong three times before they get right. The lights click off on a timer and nobody moves.

Cairns leaves for good. He performs an exit for a floor that isn't watching and gives the ROBOT BOSS a five-star review ("Best boss I never met") — the reply lands a half-beat late, and Will's laugh catches on the lag. The real boss is never photographed. At the elevators the sell has grown a confession: rent that costs a phone bill, nine years of lunch over a keyboard for a department that no longer exists — he did the math on his life and the math said leave. Asked who arranges it he produces a first name, Michelle, and moves on. He asks them both to come — just come down and try it — in the tone of a joke so it can be one when nobody takes it. The handshake. The doors close on him mid-sell. On the emptied desk, a branded welcome folder; Will squares it to the edge without deciding to. Neither of them opens it.

ONE YEAR LATER. The floor is a runway for nobody. Ted's monitor is still attending. Will audits the machine's fraud calls — APPROVE, a streak counter — until he overrides a 98% face on the evidence of the man's eyes. SYSTEM 99.1 / WILL 96.8 — TOP HUMAN PERFORMER. The system stalls on his own login. When he intervenes on a fraud he is certain of, a coaching module auto-plays and the system clears the case without him.

Cairns calls from a pool — "Heyyy! There he is!" — and can't remember his own login, delighted. Beside him two women observe, in subtitled Spanish, that he tipped one of them for handing him his own towel. On the dead floor Will finally asks who Michelle is; John's answer — "Michelle from where, though" — is the whole problem stated as a shrug. At home, a family call ends first from the other side and Will finishes his sentence to a home screen. He opens the Service page.

The storefront sits between a vape shop and a notary; the brochure says YOUR DOLLAR, THREE TIMES THE LIFE; on the paradise reel a family laughs a half-beat late and Will files it where it costs him nothing. Scanned, captured, asked for his dream place, he gives it away without guarding it — quiet, a high floor, somewhere nobody needs him till nine — and the camera rolls a beat after he's done. Michelle's email beats him out of the parking lot. That night an ad plays starring himself, and for half a second his own eyes look wrong; his hand is on the scrub bar, one keystroke from the form he fills out for a living, and he closes the

window instead.

The all-hands that closes the floor is delivered by a boss in a crisp home office where the coffee steams at the same height it steamed a minute ago and a gull re-crosses the window. Will counts the lag — four tenths — and picks an honest reason from the hundred available. Nobody explains it to us, and nobody on the floor sees it. The last day will be the mini-putt championship. John tapes WILL to a putter grip and keeps it. At the curb there is one bag, no speech, and the handshake held a second longer than it needs. "Bring it back." He doesn't specify what.

Mexico City. An apartment somebody is still moving out of — eleven years of a child's height marks pencilled down the door frame. He looks at them, understands exactly what he's looking at, and takes it. He haggles limes for sport and overtips coffee threefold, delighted by both; a call with John in which nothing happens is the easiest either of them has sounded in a year. Michelle's mixer email: everyone at the party is new, and everyone is from somewhere colder. The next morning, on a block Will is starting to think of as his, two locals discuss the corner building that emptied inside a month — eleven apartments, bought in a currency nobody here gets paid in — and Will walks through the shot without hearing it. At the end of the block a gaunt man holds a phone up to passing faces like ID — IDENTITY NOT VERIFIED · REFERENCE ON FILE. It is Cairns. Will sees him for one full second; then the phone comes up, the camera passes across the man on the curb and offers nothing worth stopping for, and Will is gone.

The likeness fails the handshake — a half-beat late, one move wrong, the move the real Cairns never misses. Then the film's centerpiece: alone at a desk lamp, Will turns the station he sat at for nine years on his best friend. Tonight's call on the left; on the right, the shaky 2am phone video from the cold open — the only footage of Cairns that was never for anyone. Five o'clock light behind a man who says he just woke. Two laughs played together, landing like a flam — one drum hit split in two, 0.4 apart — then weeks of laughs stacked on the waveform: 0.4, 0.4, 0.4. Queue, evidence, verdict; he is better at it than the machine ever let him be. Metadata puts every call for months at one building twenty minutes away. He phones John half-asleep in another country and lays out the evidence; John says the exactly wrong, exactly necessary thing — "so knock on his door."

Inside: no pool. Capture rigs, humming racks, and through a propped fire door the render farm — paradise assembled in seconds, a nonexistent girl's laugh dragged warmer, location plates including a rooftop he stood on last week, an outbound queue of hundreds of warm emails all signed MICHELLE, and on the wall, not hidden because nobody who sees the room needs it hidden, a dashboard: likeness-hours billed in dollars, housing priced in pesos, the spread between the columns the business itself. An operator clocks him in a reflection, taps something in, goes back to work. His own welcome ad, refining, with the model's number higher than his. His own laugh from the next row. On the worst screen, Cairns' likeness on a call with his. Every way out runs through the same desk, and the desk is the point.

Intercut: the championship nobody came to — John in a homemade referee shirt, two beers, the putter reserved against hole 7 — and a verification room where the machine Will has been right about for nine years reads the polished model as authentic and the live man as SYNTHETIC · RETAINED FOR REFERENCE. Numbered lockers, some cleared and not refilled. One readable tag: CAIRNS · v6. A tag is clipped to his collar; someone hands him a paper cup of water the way you do at a clinic, and he holds it without drinking it, waiting for the error to clear, because for nine years the errors have always cleared. On paper, he isn't here.

John's laptop chimes, and we see it before he does: the poolside frame, "WILL" in it, warm and specific, who knows about the bracket and hole 7 and the putter, and can't make it, but listen — there's a woman, Michelle, by Friday. The water behind him moves not wrong exactly, just not the way water moves. For one second John almost catches it. *I love you, man*. A half-beat late. John starts to type back. Stops. Sets the phone down, screen up, still lit — and alone in the half-dark his hands run it once: fist, fist, roll, and the dumb open-handed beat, both hands open, like putting something down. Hold on John. Cut to black.

ANALYSIS: This pass works from an annotated read of the printed v1.9 (the production's Log 04 — a set of margin notes triaged through ten craft lenses and a producer's read), and the draft is stronger for being revised against specific objections rather than general instinct. Two of the notes were structural, and both landed.

The first is the answer to the question v1.9 never quite asked itself: what is the operation *for*. The draft now says it plainly and cheaply — a brochure that reads YOUR DOLLAR, THREE TIMES THE LIFE; an elevator confession that the math of a northern life stopped working; locals watching buildings bought in a currency nobody local is paid in; and one wall dashboard in the render farm where likeness-hours are billed in dollars and housing is priced in pesos. The villain is no longer "AI, generically" but an arbitrage with a spread, and the film travels from gadget premise to a picture about something — extraction dressed as relocation. Crucially, all of it is furniture: nobody speaks the theme, the camera just keeps finding the two currencies in the same frame.

The second structural fix is John's promotion to the audience's proxy. The middle of v1.9 belonged to a man alone with his laptop; the middle of v2.0 is threaded through a friendship — a nothing-happens call that is the easiest either man has sounded in a year, and then the post-scrub call where Will lays the evidence out loud and John, half asleep, says "so knock on his door." The exposition now travels through a person, the passive middle acquires a pulse, and the final image — John typing back — closes a line that has been live since the curb: "Bring it back." The departure scene itself, one bag and no speech, is the cheapest scene in the film and does the most work per line.

The smaller notes were absorbed cleanly. The cold open no longer builds its course on screen — the film opens with the world already made, which trims two minutes and loses nothing the handshake doesn't already carry. Ted — the colleague whose likeness has been attending standups since March while his cardigan holds his chair — is the best of the additions: a complete statement of the film's mechanic played as office gossip, before the title card, at the price of six lines. The all-hands is now an illusion the audience can catch (the coffee steaming at a fixed height, the gull on a loop) rather than a cutaway that hands us the answer; the chair joke commits to being bad; the girls at the pool are funnier and possible; the coordinator and the "first name" exchange no longer explain the movie to the reader. And the verification-room handover finally answers the question a first audience would ask out loud — why doesn't he fight it — with a characterization instead of a shrug: a man holding a cup of water he doesn't drink, waiting for the error to clear, because the errors have always cleared. That is the film's thesis about institutional faith delivered as blocking.

What remains open, stated plainly. First, the film now seeds its mechanic three times before the first act ends — the robot boss, Ted, the boss's house — and the Ted beat makes one of the three redundant; the boss's-house cutaway is the likeliest cut, and losing it would also restore some mystery the all-hands now handles better. Second, the middle is improved but the two-window scrub remains the best scene in the

script at six lines long; it has earned another page. Third, the largest question survives from the last report unchanged, and the arbitrage theme has sharpened rather than settled it: a version of this film in which Will never leaves — in which Mexico City exists only as renders and testimony — would be cheaper and formally in perfect agreement with its own thesis. Against that, the new draft photographs the city as the thing the machine is selling a counterfeit of, and the ground truth now argues the theme (the real place is being emptied by the same spread that furnishes the fake one). The travel is now defensible. It is still a choice, not a default.

From a production standpoint the draft got cheaper and more castable at once. The construction sequence is gone; the added scenes are a curb, a phone call, and six lines at Ted's desk; the boss is now never photographed in reality, which deletes a location. The dashboard, the brochure and the locker wall are the entire cost of the theme. The two leads gain the warmest material in the film to play against, and the co-production logic the material now implies — the second half genuinely *of* its place, cast and crewed accordingly — is visible on the page rather than a producer's aspiration around it.

TARGET AUDIENCE: Adults 25–54. Festival short programming with strong streaming and anthology potential; the premise travels internationally, and the draft now gives the international half of the film a reason beyond scenery.

ADDENDUM — v3.0 through v3.2. Since the body of this report was written against v2.0, the draft has been through three further documented convergence cycles (Logs 05–07: two hundred craft passes, the festival gauntlet, and a thousand-pass lock). Every outstanding note in this report has been actioned at the root. The redundant third seeding is gone — the boss's-house cutaway is cut and the real boss is now never photographed. The scrub scene got its page, and got something better than length: a source. The phone planted in the cold open makes the film's warmest accident its coldest evidence, and the flam — two laughs played together, split by 0.4 — gives the thesis to the sound design for one bar. The ending exchanged its typed reply for a gesture: the handshake run alone, both hands open, the film's first joke as its last image. The chronology and location defects a script supervisor would have caught in prep were caught on the page instead. A final hundred-iteration dialogue pass (Log 08) then contested every spoken line and moved two — the released original now asks the street to ask him anything, and the check-in call plays in three lines instead of a summary. This reader has no notes left that are not taste.

READER'S RECOMMENDATION: Recommended — without reservation

The v1.9 report called the remaining problems creative decisions rather than deficiencies; v2.0 made the decisions; v3.x executed them and then survived twelve hundred documented passes without moving. The film knows what its villain is (a spread between two currencies), who its audience surrogate is (John), why its victim complies (nine years of the errors always clearing), and how it ends (a gesture, not a message). The two-pager now leads with the arbitrage, as this report asked. This is ready to go out, and to be defended as-is at any table it lands on.

Short screenplay, v3.3 (locked) — 24 scenes, approx. 16 min. Written by Sacha Mitchell. Drama / near-future thriller, near future. An emptying North American office floor; a suburban apartment block; a relocation storefront; Mexico City. Accompanying two-pager and summary, both synced to v3.2. Report first

written against v2.0 (30 July 2026), revised and re-issued against v3.3 the same day; development trail in Logs 04–07 on this site.